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DYNAMICS IN PRE-SERVICE TEACHERS' BELIEFS ABOUT MULTILINGUALISM AND LINGUISTIC DIVERSITY IN EDUCATION: A Q METHODOLOGY STUDY

I. CONTEXT & OBJECTIVE

In many countries, multilingual pupils who also use languages other than the official language/s of schooling face more obstacles for their academic success than monolingual pupils (OECD/EU, 2018, p. 192). One reason for this situation are teachers' lower performance expectations of multilingual students, which, in turn, negatively influence multilingual students' competence development (Lorenz & Gentrup, 2017, p. 35). Thus, teachers' assumptions and beliefs about multilingual students and their language use have significant impact on these students' learning. While studies on in-service teachers' beliefs about multilingualism have only recently been conducted (Alisaari, Heikkola, Commins, & Acquah, 2019; Lundberg, 2019a, 2019b), studies on pre-service teachers' beliefs about multilingualism are still scarce. This study aims to examine this underexplored issue by investigating 1) pre-service teachers' beliefs about languages in education and 2) how these beliefs develop by attending a teacher training course on multilingualism in education.

II. RELEVANT RESEARCH FINDINGS

- Teachers' beliefs are an integral part of teachers' professional competence (Baumert & Kunter, 2013, p. 37–38)
- Teachers' beliefs influence teachers' perception of classroom events (Roose, Vantieghem, Vanderlinde, & Avermaet, 2019, p. 147–148) and so also their classroom practice (OECD, 2009, p. 118)
- If seen as an integral part of teachers' professional competence, beliefs can change during professionalization (Schmeisser, Krauss, Bruckmaier, Ufer, & Blum, 2013, p. 64)
- Higher knowledge about languages in education seems to positively influence teachers' beliefs about multilingualism (Hammer, Fischer, & Koch-Priewe, 2016, p. 160–161)

III. RESEARCH DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

Teachers' beliefs are defined as "psychologically held understandings and assumptions about phenomena or objects of the world that are felt to be true, have both implicit and explicit aspects, and influence people's interactions with the world" (Voss, Kleickmann, Kunter, & Hachfeld, 2013, p. 249–250). To investigate such a subjective and complex phenomenon as beliefs Q-methodology (Q) is regarded as particularly well suited. In Q, participants are provided with different statements on a topic (known as Q-sample) and are asked to sort, rank and order these statements in a sorting grit (Paige, 2014, p. 639). In this study, an adapted version of the Q-sample used by Lundberg (Lundberg, 2019b) about Swiss in-service teachers' beliefs about multilingualism will be used at the beginning and at the end of a teacher training course on multilingualism in education. Data will be analysed by means of an inverted factor analysis which allows for a better by-person exploration of the data than a regular factor analysis (Watts & Stenner, 2005, S. 71–72). Potential interviews with participants might elucidate how participants explain potential differences in their Q-sortings of the pre- and the post-test. Figure 1 on page 2 contains a visual overview of the research project.

IV. EXPECTED OUTCOMES

Based on relevant prior research on teacher expertise and competence development, also for this study, it can be expected that study participants' beliefs about multilingualism in education develop towards more positive beliefs about multilingualism in education.

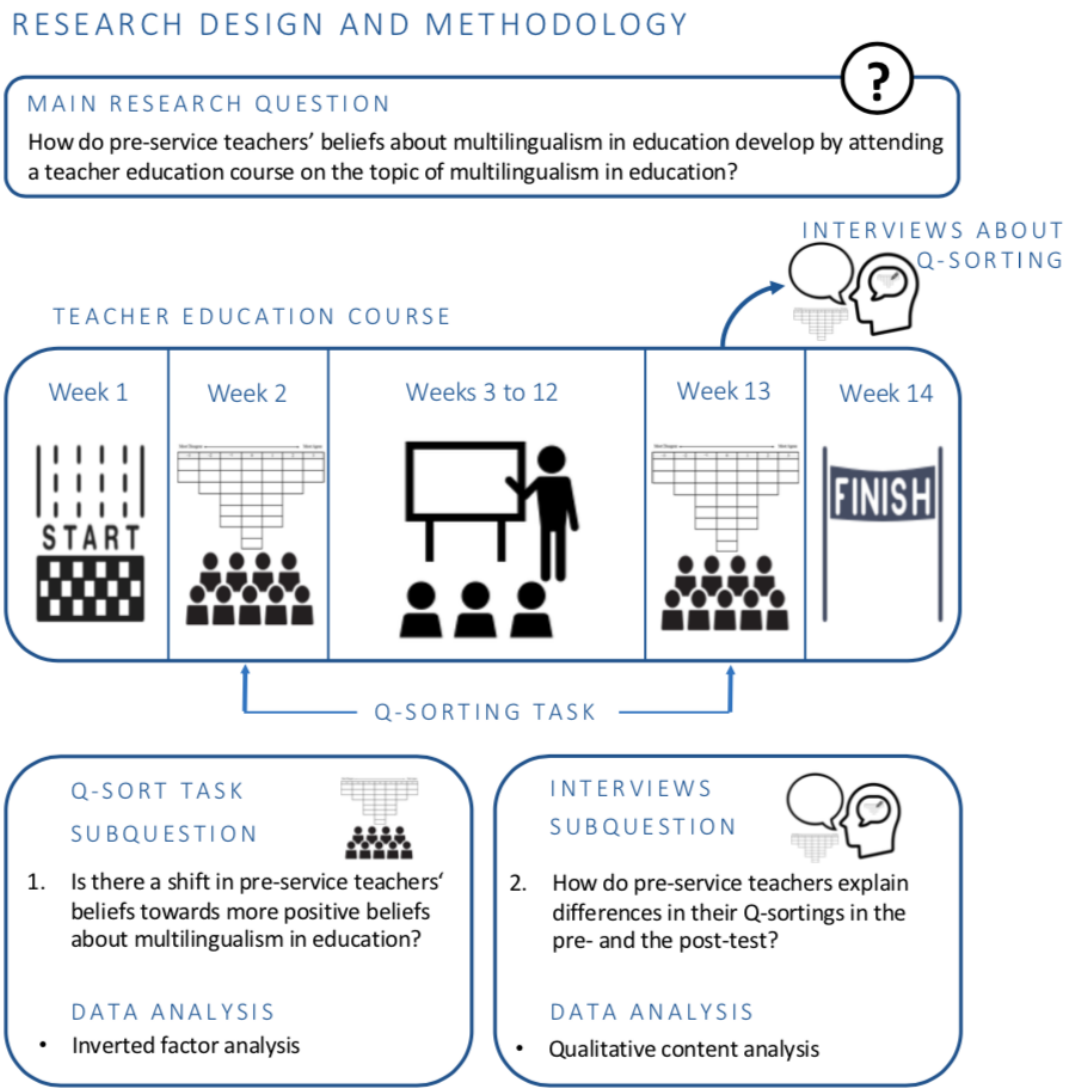

Figure 1 - Visual overview of the research project

Literature

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Forschungsethische Überlegungen

Das hier dargestellte Forschungsvorhaben ist stark „abhängig von und situiert in den Beziehungen des Forschers zu Personen und deren Umfeld“ (Legutke und Schramm 2016, 109), im konkreten Fall zu den Studierenden im Seminar. Um hier eine Grundlage für eine möglichst vertrauensvolle Zusammenarbeit zu schaffen, wird möglichst hohe Transparenz hinsichtlich der Ziele, Verfahren und Ergebnisse des Forschungsvorhabens angestrebt. Entsprechend werden Informationen zu Zielen, Zeitdauer, Procedere, Vor- und Nachteilen einer Teilnahme, Datenschutz, Ansprechpersonen und zur weiteren Verwendung der Daten bereits im Vorfeld in der Lehrveranstaltungsbeschreibung im Vorlesungsverzeichnis der Universität Wien veröffentlicht. Außerdem werden diese Informationen auch in einer informierten Einwilligungserklärung zusammengefasst und eine Woche vor Beginn der Datenerhebung mit den potentiellen Forschungspartner*innen besprochen. Die Studienteilnahme ist freiwillig und kann jederzeit ohne Angabe von Gründen unterbrochen werden. Um zu vermeiden, dass potentielle Forschungspartner*innen sich zur Teilnahme gedrängt fühlen – schließlich besteht ein gewisses Abhängigkeitsverhältnis durch die Beziehung Lehrender-Studierende – werden die Daten völlig anonym mittels von den Studierenden selbst kreierten Identifikationscode erhoben. Dieser Identifikationscode ist lediglich den Studierenden bekannt und ermöglicht es die Daten aus der Eingangs- und Schlusserhebung trotz Anonymität der Studierenden miteinander in Beziehung zu setzen. Die ausgefüllten Fragebögen werden von einer Studentin bzw. einem Studenten eingesammelt, während der der Forscher den Raum verlässt, wodurch die Möglichkeit der Studierenden verbessert werden soll, die Fragebögen auch nicht abzugeben.